

GENTLE PARENTING TODDLER TANTRUM TOOLKIT

20 Calm-Down Strategies, Scripts & Visual Tools

for Parents of Children Ages 1-5

By Daniel Tesfamariam

WHY TODDLERS HAVE TANTRUMS (It's Normal!)

Tantrums are NOT bad behavior. They're a sign your child's brain is overwhelmed and they haven't yet developed the skills to regulate emotions.

BRAIN SCIENCE: The prefrontal cortex (logic, self-control) isn't fully developed until age 25. Toddlers are literally unable to 'calm down on command.'

YOUR JOB: Be the calm in their storm. Co-regulate (stay calm yourself) and they will learn to self-regulate over time.

THE P.A.U.S.E. METHOD

When a tantrum starts, use this 5-step framework:

P - PAUSE. Stop what you're doing. Take 3 breaths.

A - ACKNOWLEDGE. 'I see you're really upset right now.'

U - UNDERSTAND. What need is unmet? (hungry? tired? overwhelmed?)

S - SUPPORT. Offer connection: 'I'm here. Would you like a hug?'

E - EMPATHIZE. 'It's hard when we can't have what we want.'

AFTER the storm passes:

1. Validate: 'You had really big feelings.'

2. Name it: 'That was frustration/anger/sadness.'

3. Problem-solve: 'Next time, you can...'

SCRIPTS: WHAT TO SAY (20 Common Situations)

When: They can't have something

Say: "I hear you. You really want that. It's okay to feel disappointed. The answer is still no, AND I love you."

When: They hit/bite/throw

Say: "I won't let you hurt. Hitting hurts. You can stomp your feet or squeeze this pillow instead."

When: They won't leave the park

Say: "We're leaving in 5 minutes. Would you like to go down the slide one more time or swing?"

When: They won't share

Say: "It's hard to share. You can have it for 2 more minutes, then it's your friend's turn."

When: They want YOU to do it

Say: "You want help. I'll help you start, then you can finish. I believe you can do it."

SCRIPTS (continued)

When: They're frustrated (can't do something)

Say: "That IS frustrating! Would you like to try again, or take a break and come back?"

When: They say 'I HATE YOU'

Say: "I can see you're really angry. It's okay to be angry. I love you even when you're mad."

When: They won't get dressed

Say: "It's time to get dressed. Would you like the blue shirt or the red shirt? You choose!"

When: They melt down at bedtime

Say: "Your body is tired even if your brain doesn't think so. Let's do our calm-down routine together."

When: Public tantrum (store/restaurant)

Say: "I see you're having a hard time. Let's step outside for a minute to feel better."

FEELINGS CHART FOR KIDS

(Print, laminate, and use daily! 'Point to how you feel right now.')

HAPPY :) SAD :(ANGRY >:(SCARED :O
EXCITED !! TIRED zzz FRUSTRATED ?! NERVOUS ~~~
PROUD * LONELY . SILLY :P CALM ~

'I feel _____ because _____.'

(Help kids fill in the sentence with the chart)

10 CALM-DOWN STRATEGIES (For Kids)

(Print as cards, let child CHOOSE which one to try)

1. Belly Breathing: Breathe in like smelling a flower, out like blowing a candle. 5 times.
2. Tight Squeeze Hug: Ask: 'Can I give you a tight squeeze?' or let them hug a stuffed animal.
3. Stomp It Out: Stomp feet 10 times. Get the angry energy OUT through your feet.
4. Count to 10: Count slowly together. Whisper by the time you reach 10.
5. Safe Space: Go to a designated 'calm corner' with pillows and soft things.
6. Ice Cube Hold: Hold an ice cube until it melts. The sensation redirects the brain.
7. Draw Your Feelings: Give paper and crayons. 'Draw how big your feeling is.'
8. Body Shake: Shake hands, arms, legs, whole body for 30 seconds. Then freeze.
9. Name 5 Things: 5 things you can see, 4 you can hear, 3 you can touch...
10. Blow Bubbles: Blowing = controlled breathing. Watching = calming. Win-win.

TANTRUM TRACKING LOG (Find Patterns!)

Track tantrums for 2 weeks. You'll notice patterns you can PREVENT.

DATE	TIME	TRIGGER	DURATION	WHAT HELPED	PATTERN?
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____	____	_____	____min	_____	_____
____	____	_____	____min	_____	_____
____	____	_____	____min	_____	_____
____	____	_____	____min	_____	_____
____	____	_____	____min	_____	_____
____	____	_____	____min	_____	_____
____	____	_____	____min	_____	_____
____	____	_____	____min	_____	_____
____	____	_____	____min	_____	_____
____	____	_____	____min	_____	_____

PATTERNS I NOTICE: _____

Common triggers: ☐ Hungry ☐ Tired ☐ Transitions ☐ Overstimulated

Prevention plan: _____

TANTRUM PREVENTION CHECKLIST

Most tantrums are PREVENTABLE. Daily check:

- ☐ Fed regularly (no more than 3 hours between food)
- ☐ Slept enough (age-appropriate nap + bedtime)
- ☐ Given choices throughout the day (autonomy!)
- ☐ Warned before transitions ('5 more minutes, then...')
- ☐ Had 1-on-1 connection time with parent today
- ☐ Physical activity/outdoor play today
- ☐ Not overscheduled (downtime is essential!)
- ☐ Routines are predictable and consistent

If 3+ are unchecked: a meltdown is LIKELY coming. Address the need!

By Daniel Tesfamariam | Every tantrum is a chance to teach - not punish.